

Mineral Extraction for AI Supply Chain

This is a new form of colonialism.

Miners carry out the invisible work behind AI. In African nations, children are being forced to work in mines to support the AI technologies we use. These individuals are not paid adequate wages, while profits are monopolized by large corporations.

DRC cobalt mines

Mining cobalt, lithium, and rare earths powers batteries, phones, and chips. The supply chain often depends on exploited labor and environmental destruction. Children and adults mine cobalt in dangerous, often unregulated pits. Work can last up to 12 hours a day. Amnesty reports that around 40,000 children work in southern DRC mining areas, that miners often work long hours without protective gear, and that child labor is tied to hazardous conditions and low pay.



Picture : Human Rights Watch



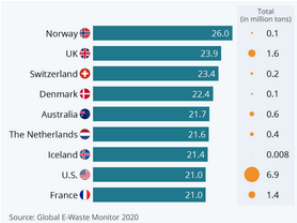
Image: ChatGPT

The Wage Gap Between Mine Workers and Tech CEOs

There is a vast wage gap between workers in Congolese cobalt mines, who often earn poverty wages, and CEOs of American tech companies, whose compensation can reach hundreds or even tens of thousands of dollars per day. In addition electronic devices such as iPhones—manufactured using materials like cobalt and lithium—are expensive; yet, despite the substantial profits generated by tech companies, these earnings are not reinvested in the children working at the mining sites where these resources are extracted, but are instead hoarded by the corporations.



Picture: Humanium



Source: Global E-Waste Monitor 2020

Countries that produce e-waste

Problems on E-waste

The colonial-style exploitation of developing nations surrounding the AI industry extends not only to the production phase but also to the disposal phase. E-waste is the world's fastest-growing domestic waste stream, with 62 million tonnes generated in 2022. Although the majority of e-waste is generated in developed nations, it is frequently exported to developing countries. However, these developing nations lack the technology to properly recycle such waste; consequently, its accumulation is giving rise to environmental problems.

Muntosh's experience with disasters at mining sites

According to Save the Children's reports, Muntosh was around six years old when he witnessed his brother being killed in a landslide at a cobalt mine. Despite this, Muntosh continued to work in the mines because his family needed the money. He spent years in the mines and only later entered a program to catch up on his schooling. However, the damage had already been done. He said that after finding and removing a large block of cobalt, his body hurt constantly, and the pain never left him.

The "invisible work" behind AI is carried out by miners

Miners work long hours for low wages to supply the minerals needed for batteries and digital technology. Those who profit the most are usually far removed from the mines. Tech companies, battery manufacturers, mineral traders, and other corporations at the top of the supply chain reap the greatest financial rewards. Meanwhile, miners endure harsh conditions for only a tiny fraction of the value they create. The greatest profits accumulate in corporate headquarters, investment firms, and wealthy consumer markets, rather than in the communities where extraction occurs. These corporations treat the miners as if they were a colony. This is why some critics describe the system as a form of digital colonialism.

Attribution, include citation of pictures

- Oliver. "Child Labor in the Mines of the Democratic Republic of Congo - Humanium." Humanium, 6 Apr. 2016. www.humanium.org/en/child-labor-in-the-mines-of-the-democratic-republic-of-congo/.
- Amnesty International. "IS MY PHONE POWERED BY CHILD LABOUR?" Amnesty.org, 10 June 2016. www.amnesty.org/en/latest/campaigns/2016/06/drc-cobalt-child-labour/.
- Save the Children. "DRC: Cobalt Mines, Child Labour and the Green Transition." Save the Children International, 4 Nov. 2024. www.savethechildren.net/stories/drc-cobalt-mines-child-labour-and-green-transition.
- Sawyer, Ida. "Child Labor and Human Rights Violations in the Mining Industry of the Democratic Republic of Congo." Human Rights Watch, 14 July 2022. www.hrw.org/news/2022/07/14/child-labor-and-human-rights-violations-mining-industry-democratic-republic-congo.
- Buchholz, Katharina. "Infographic: The Countries Producing the Most E-Waste." Statista Infographics, 25 Feb. 2021. www.statista.com/chart/24291/e-waste-by-country/.
- Bureau of International Labor Affairs. "Findings on the Worst Forms of Child Labor - Democratic Republic of the Congo | U.S. Department of Labor." U.S. Department of Labor, 2023. www.dol.gov/agencies/ilab/resources/reports/child-labor/congo-democratic-republic-drc.